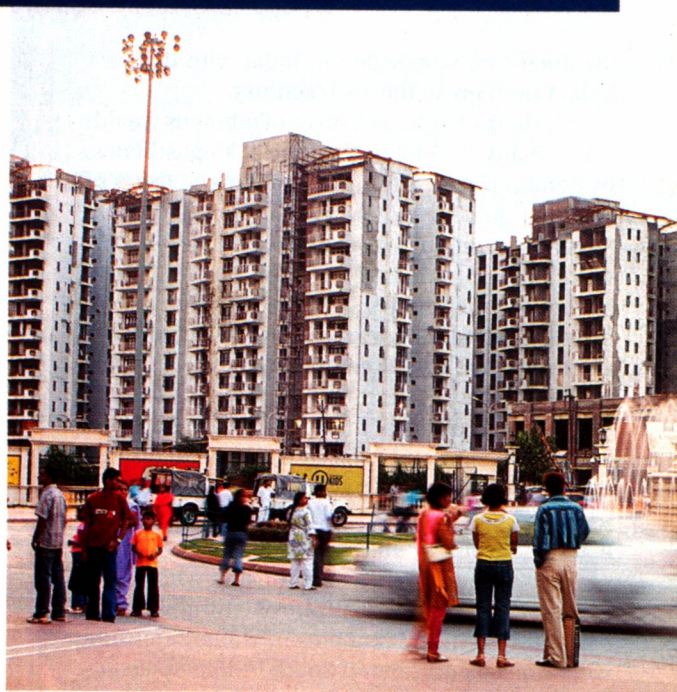




RAVI S SAHANI



HEMANT CHAWLA



BHASKAR PAUL



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us at such a speed that it now abuts the edge of the Kapashera farm, and what is proudly touted as the largest mall in Asia is coming up a quarter of a mile from the house. What was farmland and a pool for water buffaloes when we moved in, is now a mass of cranes flanked by billboards advertising the latest laptops and iPods. Behind us, an eight-lane superhighway rises above the treetops on elevated bridges.

The speed of the development of Gurgaon is breathtaking to anyone used to the plodding growth rates of Western Europe: the sort of construction that would take 25 years in Britain,

seems to come up here in five months—even if, at the end of it, the 'luxury' flats will probably only have electricity for a couple of hours a day and the water supply will be intermittent at best.

The speed of change in Gurgaon reflects the growth of the Indian economy in general. So extraordinary is all this to someone like me who first saw the plodding India of 1984—the India of the Licence Raj, of six months' queues at Mahanagar Telephone Nigam and of the clumpy Hindustan Ambassador—that it is easy to forget how little any of this talk of India's great wealth and speed of growth would have surprised any of

RAPID RISE: The speed of development in cities is breathtaking